

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management

Northern Trans-Pennine & Western Britain Investment Memorandum

The Borderlands High-Speed Railway

Whitehaven – Carlisle Modernisation & Carlisle – Newcastle High-Speed Line

A Sovereign Infrastructure Investment Proposal

Executive Summary

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management proposes the second phase of the Northern Coastal Railway programme:

The Borderlands High-Speed Railway (BHSR)

This project consists of two complementary schemes:

Phase I

Whitehaven – Carlisle Main Line Upgrade

Phase II

A new 125mph Carlisle–Newcastle High-Speed Railway

Together, these projects would connect the Irish Sea economic corridor to North East England, creating a fast east-west railway across the north of Britain.

1. Strategic Vision

The proposed Irish Sea Northern Spine Railway would terminate at Whitehaven.

The next stage is to extend this high-capacity corridor eastwards through Carlisle and onward to Newcastle, creating a continuous strategic railway from the Irish Sea to the North Sea.

The resulting corridor would be:

Whitehaven → Carlisle → Newcastle

This would link:

- West Cumbria
- Sellafield
- Carlisle
- Hexham
- Newcastle
- Tyneside

into a single integrated economic corridor.

The existing Tyne Valley Line already provides the principal east-west rail connection between Carlisle and Newcastle, while the Cumbrian Coast Line links Whitehaven to Carlisle. Both routes have long been identified as requiring capacity, speed and reliability improvements.

Phase I

Whitehaven – Carlisle Main Line Upgrade

Scope

Upgrade the existing Cumbrian Coast Line between Whitehaven and Carlisle into a modern regional main line.

Works include:

- Full electrification (25kV AC)
- ETCS digital signalling
- Selective double-tracking
- Passing loops
- Curve easing
- Bridge and tunnel improvements
- Freight capacity upgrades
- Modern stations

Existing regional transport strategies have recommended line-speed improvements, additional passing capacity, signalling upgrades, improved freight capability and better connections at Carlisle.

Target Journey Time

Journey	Current	Proposed
Whitehaven → Carlisle	~70–80 min	35 minutes

Strategic Benefits

- Sellafield workforce connectivity
 - Faster freight access to the West Coast Main Line
 - Improved access to Carlisle
 - Better resilience for the national rail network
 - More attractive commuter services
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Phase II

Carlisle – Newcastle High-Speed Railway

New Infrastructure

Construct a new electrified 125mph railway broadly following the Tyne Valley transport corridor while bypassing the slowest and most constrained sections of the existing route.

The new railway would complement rather than replace the existing Tyne Valley Line, which would continue to serve intermediate communities and freight traffic.

Principal Stations

- Carlisle
 - Brampton
 - Haltwhistle
 - Hexham
 - Prudhoe
 - Newcastle Central
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Railway Standard

Feature	Specification
Maximum speed	125 mph
Electrification	25kV AC
Track	Double track
Signalling	ETCS Level 2/3
Freight capability	Yes
Design life	100+ years

Journey Time Revolution

Journey	Current	Proposed
Carlisle → Newcastle	~80–90 min	35 minutes
Whitehaven → Newcastle	~2 hr 30 min	70 minutes
Barrow → Newcastle	~3 hr+	95 minutes
Blackpool → Newcastle (<i>via Irish Sea Spine</i>)	~3 hr+	90 minutes
Preston → Newcastle (<i>via Irish Sea Spine</i>)	~2 hr 45 min	75 minutes

These proposed times are conceptual targets for a new-build high-speed regional corridor rather than forecasts based on existing infrastructure.

Economic Impact

A New Northern East–West Growth Corridor

The railway would unite:

- Lancashire
- Cumbria
- Tyneside
- Northumberland

into one connected investment region.

Combined population:

Approximately 4 million people

Combined economy:

Approximately £110–120 billion GVA

Productivity Impact

Improved accessibility supports:

- larger labour markets
- faster business travel
- stronger university collaboration
- defence and nuclear supply chains
- tourism

Illustrative long-term assumptions:

Benefit	Annual Value
Productivity uplift (≈1.5%)	£1.7bn

Benefit	Annual Value
Tourism growth	£350m
Commercial development	£500m
Freight and logistics efficiencies	£450m

Total Long-Term Economic Benefit

£3–4 billion per annum (illustrative strategic estimate)

Strategic Industrial Benefits

Sellafield

- Faster workforce access
- Improved freight resilience
- Better links to research centres

Carlisle

- Strengthened role as the principal rail interchange between Scotland, North West England and the North East

Newcastle

- Faster access to western ports
 - Expanded labour market
 - Improved connectivity for advanced manufacturing and digital industries
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Capital Investment

Component	Estimated Cost
Whitehaven–Carlisle upgrade	£2.5bn
Carlisle–Newcastle high-speed line	£10–12bn
Stations	£1bn
Electrification & signalling	£1.5bn

Total Programme

£15–17 billion

Investment Characteristics

- 100-year strategic infrastructure asset
 - Electrified low-carbon railway
 - Capacity for passenger and freight traffic
 - Improved national network resilience
 - Strong regional regeneration potential
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Strategic Outcome

When combined with the proposed Irish Sea Northern Spine Railway, the Borderlands High-Speed Railway would create a continuous fast rail corridor:

Preston → Blackpool → Fleetwood → Barrow-in-Furness → Whitehaven → Carlisle → Newcastle

This would establish a new west-to-east economic axis across northern England, linking the Irish Sea with the North Sea and connecting major industrial, energy, defence and tourism centres through a modern electrified rail network.

Note: The Whitehaven–Carlisle upgrade builds upon widely discussed improvements to the Cumbrian Coast Line. The Carlisle–Newcastle 125mph railway described here is a conceptual new-build proposal rather than an announced government project. Existing policy discussions focus on upgrading the Tyne Valley Line rather than constructing a parallel high-speed route.